missile defence system – increasing Chinese strategic vulnerability – albeit against strong Chinese protests.[46]

Sporadic US freedom-of-navigation patrols have not been able to deter China from demonstrating its control in the South China Sea and building upon the disputed shoals. China's active campaign against the Arbitration Award on the South China Sea blunted international backlash against it, as neither the ASEAN nor the European Union formally supported the Award or advocated its implementation.[47] However, resentment in the region, especially in the countries involved in the dispute, has deepened, and states might be more determined now than before to forge arrangements for defending their interests. China, buoyed by its impressive accomplishments and helped by US ineptness in not managing a working relationship with Russia, has embraced the idea of Chinese exceptionalism. The result is that China's leadership does not seem to comprehend fully the concerns, and even the hostile reactions, to its great power aspirations in the Indo-Pacific region. For instance, during a visit to China in 2018, then–Malaysian Prime Minister Mahathir Mohamad, well known for his earlier anti-Western rhetoric, also voiced criticism of China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI).[48]

While China seeks acknowledgement of its growing primacy in Asia, it desires parity with the United States in the management of global affairs. President Xi Jinping's early effort in 2013 to forge a Sino–US entente based on a "new type of great power relationship" was spurned by President Obama, and there is little chance of this being tried while President Trump remains in the saddle, but the effort could be revived under a different US administration.[49]

It is argued that, following its extraordinary economic rise and based on wisdom about great power politics, China could be headed to establish itself as a regional hegemon.[50] A by-product of such a development would be attempts by